Case Study: The "Urgent Financial Aid" Phish

What the Crime Is

Phishing is a form of social engineering where an attacker masquerades as a trusted entity (like a university, bank, or government agency) to deceive victims into revealing sensitive information. The goal is typically to steal login credentials, financial data, or install malware on the victim's device.

How it Typically Happens (Step-by-Step)

1. **Baiting:** The attacker crafts a highly realistic email using stolen university logos and professional language. The subject line often creates a sense of urgency, such as *"Action Required: Your Financial Aid Disbursement is Pending."*
2. **The Hook:** The email contains a link to a "Student Portal" to "verify your identity" or "accept the funds" within 24 hours.
3. **The Deception:** When the student clicks the link, they are taken to a fake website that looks identical to the official university login page (**typo squatting**), using a URL like myuniversity-portal.net instead of myuniversity.edu.
4. **The Theft:** As the student enters their username and password, the attacker captures the credentials in real-time. If the site asks for a "security code" (MFA bypass), the attacker simultaneously uses the student's credentials on the *real* site to trigger and steal that code.
5. **The Payoff:** The attacker gains full access to the student's account, allowing them to change direct deposit information, access personal records, or send more phishing emails to the student's entire contact list.

Who is Targeted

While anyone can be a target, attackers frequently target **college students** during high-stress periods, such as the start of a semester (tuition deadlines) or tax season. International students are often specifically targeted with threats regarding their visa status to increase compliance.

Consequences

The consequences are often severe and multifaceted:

- **Financial Loss:** Direct theft of tuition funds or bank account draining.
- **Identity Theft:** Use of personal data to open fraudulent credit lines.
- **Academic Disruption:** Loss of access to course materials, email, and university systems during critical exam periods.
- **Reputational Damage:** Being the unwitting source of a campus-wide malware outbreak.